In 2001, however, marine archaeologists identified two underwater locations in the Gulf of Khambat that seem to be remains of large settlements that would have been flooded 7500 years ago. [21] There is still a great deal of controversy over the exact nature of these discoveries but, if true, these findings would be truly remarkable. Since I have not personally examined the evidence, I reserve my judgement for the moment. Still, it would be reasonable to say that the changes in weather patterns and the sharp rise in sea-levels must have caused significant displacements in Neolithic populations during this period.

It is often argued that migrant Neolithic groups from the Persian Gulf area took the knowledge of farming to other regions. There is indeed evidence that some of the first crops to be farmed systematically in the subcontinent, around 7000 BC in Mehrgarh, Baluchistan, were West Asian species such as wheat and barley. Thus, it used to be thought that Indians learned to farm from West Asian migrants and only later managed to domesticate local plants such as eggplant (brinjal), sugarcane and sesame. [22] More recently, however, researchers have uncovered evidence that Indians may have independently developed farming, including the cultivation of rice. If there were large urban settlements off the Gujarat coast, they too surely knew how to farm. Was farming developed by the people who lived in the submerged cities and was the technology then carried by refugees to the interiors? Or, were there parallel innovations in different places? We are still learning a lot of things about this period, and it remains a developing story.

Whatever the truth about the submerged cities and the invention of farming, we know for sure that India supported a fairly large human population by the end of the Neolithic age. Who were these people? How are they related to present-day Indians? [23]